aim to better protect Chinese infrastructure and to put Indian infrastructure at a disadvantage: this seems to have been one of the objectives of the Ladakh incursions in April 2020. A special forces attack would be motivated by the same objective as a limited sectoral attack but would use a different instrument, namely, an attack to surprise and overwhelm Indian border positions from behind rather than in a sustained frontal attack.

What are India's options in defending against these three types of attacks? Let's deal with the least likely attack first – the use of special forces behind India's border forces in combination with a frontal attack. This is China's riskiest option. The first difficulty is getting behind Indian forces either by ground infiltration or by airdrop in the hazardous Himalayan terrain. The second is that even if the infiltration succeeds, it must evade Indian special forces and other units deployed in a layered defence that are primed to react quickly and hunt down intruders. Should the Chinese special forces fail to evade Indian counterattacks, they would be captured and destroyed, handing India a strategic and public relations victory. More likely, then, is a Chinese push against Indian forces along a broad front or a grab of strategic ground in key sectors. Either way, the difficulties for China are terrain and Indian counterattacks. In many places the fighting will occur at heights of 4000 metres and above, where no armies have ever fought before (except the Indians and Pakistanis at Siachen and the Indians and Chinese in 1962). Even with acclimatized troops, any extended military operations will test troop endurance to the limit. In the winter, operations will be almost impossible given the cold and the snow.

If the Chinese make any significant gains or breakthroughs, they will confront the problem of supplying their units. The further they come, the greater their supply problems, and the easier it will be for the Indian Army to sustain its forces: in military parlance, the Chinese will have the 'exterior lines' while the Indians will have the 'interior lines'. Furthermore, despite China's massive developments in infrastructure in Tibet, logistical problems will hobble Chinese forces. The Tibetan Plateau with its flat terrain enables road and rail communications; but the flatness of the terrain means its